Three times during his speech, Kerry quoted Naftali Bennett, though he never mentioned him by name. Bennett nonetheless picked up on the reference, and he tweeted approvingly about it. “Kerry quoted me three times, anonymously, to show that we are opposed to a Palestinian state,” he wrote. “Correct.”

This was once a fringe position in Israel. No longer. In November, weeks before Kerry’s speech, the Israel Democracy Institute found that 44 per cent of Israelis supported annexing the entire West Bank, while just 38 per cent opposed it. A similar share, 42 per cent, felt that the Palestinians should not be granted equal rights under such an arrangement. “That is, a small but significant minority of the Jewish public supports a situation that the international community regards as apartheid,” the pollsters noted.[2]

The Jewish Sparta

Foreign diplomats often argue that the settlements are the core problem in the Israeli-Palestinian conflict. I personally disagree: the issues on both sides run much deeper. Yet this story of contemporary Israel began and ended in settlements—and tiny, ideological ones to boot.

Their establishment, half a century ago, helped to create a sort of feedback loop in Israeli politics and society. For one thing, it undermined the rationale for a two-state solution, decades before peace talks even started. If the government allowed Jews to settle in one corner of the territories, it had no moral argument for keeping them out of others. Indeed, it’s possible to sympathize with the settlers forced out of Gaza in 2005. There was a pragmatic argument for removing them—they required a huge amount of manpower and resources to protect—but a similar argument applies to, say, the residents of Hebron. The same goes for the residents of Amona: Why is their settlement illegal when Yitzhar, an ideological, violent community deep in the West Bank, is not?

The settlers wield power that is vastly disproportional to both their numbers and their contribution to the Israeli economy. They make up perhaps 5 per cent of the population, but ten members of the current Knesset live in settlements. Add to that the deeply pro-settler politicians who live inside of Israel proper—Naftali Bennett, Ayelet Shaked, Tzipi Hotovely, and others—and their level of representation is more than double their size. Their political views, meanwhile, have moved further and faster